

A Practical Love Publication

# Raising Loving Families in Nigeria

Raising husbands in Nigeria who will love their wives, and wives who will love their husbands, and both of them love their children, and children love their parents. A study edition with explanations.

**Charity begins at home.**

Practical Love Publications

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# About This Study Edition

This booklet is a study edition of a short leaflet from Practical Love Publications. The leaflet was written in outline form, much like a preacher's notes: a list of Bible passages, short statements, names and headings, each one a doorway into a larger teaching. Its heading sums up the burden of the whole message.

## FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

RAISING HUSBANDS IN NIGERIA WHO WILL LOVE THEIR WIVES AND WIVES WHO WILL LOVE THEIR HUSBANDS AND BOTH OF THEM LOVE THEIR CHILDREN AND CHILDREN LOVE THEIR PARENTS.

## What you are reading

Throughout this study edition you will see boxed passages marked "From the original leaflet". These give the leaflet's wording as it was printed, with spelling and punctuation lightly corrected and a few printed symbols replaced by words or plain dashes. Everything else – the explanations, headings, Scripture selections, practical steps and questions – is study notes prepared by Practical Love Publications to explain and apply the teaching. The notes are not the original author's own words, and they should not be read as if he had written or preached them in this form.

Because the leaflet is an outline, some points only name something without explaining it: a card, a church, a testimony, a well-known person. In those places the notes do not invent stories or details. Instead they explain what the point seems to illustrate, say plainly when an explanation is the notes' own reading, and give you questions and prompts so that you can apply the point to your own life.

In several places the leaflet itself quotes The Message (MSG), a modern paraphrase of the Bible. Those quotations remain inside the boxed leaflet text. All Scripture quotations in the study notes are from the King James Version (KJV). Where the older English of the King James Version may be unfamiliar, the notes explain it.

## How to use this study

- **Personal reading.** Read one section slowly with your Bible open. Look up the passages mentioned, write down what God is saying to you, and answer the questions honestly in a notebook.
- **Family devotion.** Husband and wife, or parents and children, can read a section together in the morning or evening. Let one person read the leaflet text, another read the Scripture, and then talk through the questions. Keep it short enough for the youngest child to follow.
- **House fellowship or church study group.** A leader can take one section per meeting. Members read ahead, and the meeting is spent on the Scriptures, the discussion questions and prayer for one

another's homes.

- **One section per sitting.** Each section is written to stand on its own, so do not rush. It is better to practise one point for a week than to read the whole booklet in a day and change nothing.

## The message in brief

The leaflet's heading describes love moving in four directions inside one home: husbands loving their wives, wives loving their husbands, both parents loving their children, and children loving their parents. The conviction behind the whole message is simple and searching. Love begins in the home. If it is not practised there, it will not be practised in the church, the office, the market or the government. If it is practised there, it will flow outward and bless the nation.

This hope is rooted in the closing words of the Old Testament, where God promises a work of renewal that begins with the hearts of fathers and children.

*And he shall turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers, lest I come and smite the earth with a curse.*

**Malachi 4:6 (KJV)**

Points 1 to 4 lay the foundation: loving God and teaching that love at home, loving our neighbour, Jesus' summary of the law, and the practical description of love in 1 Corinthians 13. Points 5 to 8 insist that love for God must be proved by love for people, and ask why a nation so full of worship and so richly blessed is known for corruption. Point 9 brings that question home to every family. Point 10 shows how homes and churches strengthen each other. Because points 9 and 10 carry a great deal of teaching, each is studied over two sections. Points 11 and 12 speak of testimony and overflowing blessing, and point 13 warns about the love of money. The booklet ends with a family prayer and commitment.

**Love that is not practised at home will not be practised in the nation.**

## Point 1: Deuteronomy 6 – Love God and Teach It at Home

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

#### 1. Deuteronomy 6:1-9 (MSG):

This is the commandment, the rules and regulations that your God commanded me to teach you to live out in the land you're about to cross into to possess. This is so that you will live in deep reverence before God lifelong, observing all his rules and regulations that I am commanding you, your children and your grandchildren, living good long lives.

Listen obediently, Israel. Do what you are told so that you will have a good life, a life of abundance and

bounty, just as God promised, in a land abounding in milk and honey.

Attention, Israel! God, our God! God the one and only! Love God, your God, with your whole heart: love him with all that is in you, love him with all you have got.

Write these commandments that I have given you today on your hearts. Get them inside of you and then get them inside your children. Talk about them wherever you are, sitting at home or walking in the street; talk about them from the time you get up in the morning to when you fall into bed at night. Tie them on your hands and foreheads as a reminder; inscribe them on the doorposts of your homes and on your city gates.

The leaflet begins where the Bible's teaching on family faith begins. In Deuteronomy, Moses speaks to the people of Israel on the plains of Moab, on the edge of the land God had promised them. Moses knows that the greatest danger ahead is that, once comfortable, they will forget God and fail to pass Him on to their children. So he gives them the words that Jewish people still call the Shema, from the Hebrew word for "hear".

*Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD: And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might. And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart: And thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up.*

**Deuteronomy 6:4-7 (KJV)**

*And thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thine hand, and they shall be as frontlets between thine eyes. And thou shalt write them upon the posts of thy house, and on thy gates.*

**Deuteronomy 6:8-9 (KJV)**

Notice that God's plan for keeping faith alive in a nation was not first a temple, a school or a government programme. It was the home. Every Israelite household was to become a place where the love of God was learned, spoken about and lived. Five lessons stand out for families today.

### **Lesson one: love God first**

Before Moses says anything about children, he tells the parents to love the LORD with all their heart, soul and might. Love for God is not one department of life among many; it is meant to shape how parents earn money, speak at home and spend their evenings. A home cannot give children what the parents do not have. When a father and mother truly love God, their children see a living faith rather than a Sunday routine.

### **Lesson two: in your heart before in your children**

The order of verses 6 and 7 matters: “these words ... shall be in thine heart”, and only then, “thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children”. The leaflet’s paraphrase, in the box above, makes the same order vivid: first in the parent’s heart, then in the children’s. Children quickly notice when the Bible is quoted to them but not obeyed by the one quoting it. The first classroom of faith is the parent’s own heart. A mother who confesses her faults, forgives quickly and prays honestly teaches more than a hundred lectures.

### **Lesson three: teach diligently in ordinary moments**

The Hebrew word translated “diligently” is often explained as meaning to sharpen, suggesting teaching that is repeated again and again until it is sharp and clear. God describes four ordinary moments: sitting in the house, walking by the way, lying down and rising up. In a Nigerian home these might be the family meal, the ride to school, the moment the light goes off and everyone gathers in one room, or bedtime. Faith is taught when a father explains why he refused to give a bribe, or when a child asks a question about God and a parent takes time to answer. God later expects such questions: “when thy son asketh thee in time to come” (Deuteronomy 6:20). Questions are an open door, not an interruption.

### **Lesson four: visible reminders**

Verses 8 and 9 speak of binding God’s words on the hand and between the eyes and writing them on doorposts and gates. Devout Jewish people have long practised this literally, fixing small scrolls of Scripture to their doorposts. The deeper meaning is that God’s word should guide what we do (the hand), what we think (the forehead), what happens inside our homes (the doorposts) and how we deal with the public (the gates). Bible verses on plaques and stickers are good, but the reminder must match the life. A sticker that says “God is my shepherd” on a car whose driver cheats his passengers preaches the opposite of what it says.

### **Lesson five: blessing across generations**

Moses says these are the commandments “which I command thee, thou, and thy son, and thy son’s son, all the days of thy life; and that thy days may be prolonged” (Deuteronomy 6:2). God thinks in generations. What you do in your home today affects grandchildren you may never meet. God said of Abraham, “I know him, that he will command his children and his household after him, and they shall keep the way of the LORD, to do justice and judgment” (Genesis 18:19). Notice that the way of the LORD includes justice. A family that loves God and teaches that love faithfully is building something that can outlast houses, land and bank accounts.

### **Practical steps**

- Set a short daily family devotion of ten to fifteen minutes at a time that works for your household, and keep it simple: a song, a short reading, a brief explanation and prayer.

- Choose one Bible verse a week for the whole family to learn, and write it on paper where everyone will see it, such as by the door or on the dining table.
- Use ordinary moments – meals, journeys, chores, power cuts – to talk naturally about God and about right and wrong.
- Tell your children true stories of how God has helped your family, so that faith has a history in your home.
- Welcome your children’s questions about God, even hard ones, and if you do not know an answer, look for it together.

### Questions for reflection

1. If your children described your love for God only from what they see at home, what would they say?
2. Which of the four moments in Deuteronomy 6:7 – sitting, walking, lying down, rising up – could you use better for teaching your family?
3. Are there reminders of God’s word in your home that your conduct contradicts? What needs to change?
4. What would you like your grandchildren to inherit from you spiritually, and what are you doing now to make that possible?

**Let God’s word live in your heart first, and then teach it to your children.**

## Point 2: Leviticus 19:18 – Love Your Neighbour as Yourself

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

2. Leviticus 19:18b: “Love your neighbour as yourself. I am God.”

*Thou shalt not avenge, nor bear any grudge against the children of thy people, but thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself: I am the LORD.*

**Leviticus 19:18 (KJV)**

The leaflet quotes the second half of this verse, but the whole verse is worth reading. Leviticus 19 opens with God’s call, “Ye shall be holy: for I the LORD your God am holy” (Leviticus 19:2). What follows mixes commands about worship with commands about daily life. Farmers must leave the edges of their fields for the poor (verses 9-10). Employers must not keep back a hired worker’s wages overnight (verse 13). Judges must not favour either the poor or the mighty (verse 15). The old are to be honoured (verse

32), strangers loved (verses 33-34), and traders must use honest measures (verses 35-36). In God's mind, holiness includes wages, markets and courts. Again and again the chapter ends a command with "I am the LORD", as if God signs His name under each instruction.

## **Love that refuses revenge**

The first half of the verse tells us what love looks like when we have been wronged: do not avenge, and do not bear a grudge. Many families carry grudges for years – over the sharing of land, a quarrel at a wedding, or something a spouse did long ago. Grudges are often quiet, eating away at relationships from inside. God's command to love begins with letting go of the right to get even and placing justice in His hands. This does not mean pretending that wrong was not done, but it does mean refusing to let bitterness rule the home.

## **Who is my neighbour?**

When a lawyer once asked Jesus, "And who is my neighbour?" (Luke 10:29), Jesus answered with the parable of the Good Samaritan. A man travelling from Jerusalem to Jericho was attacked by robbers and left half dead. A priest and a Levite, both religious men, saw him and passed by on the other side. Then a Samaritan – a man from a people most Jews of that time despised – stopped, treated his wounds, carried him to an inn and paid for his care.

*Which now of these three, thinkest thou, was neighbour unto him that fell among the thieves? And he said, He that shewed mercy on him. Then said Jesus unto him, Go, and do thou likewise.*

**Luke 10:36-37 (KJV)**

Jesus turned the question around. The lawyer wanted to know how far his duty stretched and who could be left out. Jesus showed that the real question is not "Who qualifies as my neighbour?" but "Will I be a neighbour to the person in front of me?" In a nation of many tribes, languages and religions, this parable speaks loudly. The person in need may not share your tribe, your church or your politics. The religious people in the story were the ones who failed; the outsider was the one who loved.

## **The nearest neighbours live in your house**

The leaflet is about the family, and this is where the command becomes most searching. The people nearest to you are your spouse, your children, your parents, your brothers and sisters, and anyone who lives under your roof, including relatives' children and house helps. It is possible to be generous to strangers and patient with church members while being harsh or careless at home. Through Isaiah, God described true devotion as feeding the hungry and clothing the naked, and then added a striking line.

*Is it not to deal thy bread to the hungry, and that thou bring the poor that are cast out to thy house? when thou seest the naked, that thou cover him; and that thou hide not thyself from thine own flesh?*

**Isaiah 58:7 (KJV)**

“Hide not thyself from thine own flesh” means do not turn away from your own relatives. The husband who hides his income from his wife, the mother who has no time to listen to her teenager, the adult child who no longer checks on ageing parents, the family member who avoids a struggling relative – all of these are hiding from their own flesh. Love for neighbour starts with the neighbour at the dining table.

## **Loving yourself rightly**

The command says “as thyself”. It assumes that people naturally care for their own needs, and it asks us to give others the same kind of care. This is not a call to selfishness. The Bible warns that in the last days “men shall be lovers of their own selves” (2 Timothy 3:2), placing self at the centre of everything. Right self-love is different. It recognises that you were made in God’s image (Genesis 1:27) and that Christ loved you enough to die for you. A person who knows they are loved by God can love others without constantly needing to prove themselves.

Paul applies this directly to marriage: “So ought men to love their wives as their own bodies. He that loveth his wife loveth himself” (Ephesians 5:28). Think of how naturally you feed yourself, treat your own wounds and protect your own reputation. That is the measure of the care you owe your spouse and family. It also means taking reasonable care of your own health, rest and spiritual life, because a parent who is exhausted, bitter or neglecting their own soul will struggle to love anyone well.

## **Practical steps**

- Name one grudge you are carrying against a family member, bring it to God in prayer, and take one step towards peace.
- This week, do for your spouse or a family member one thing you would naturally do for yourself – rest, care, protection or encouragement.
- Look around your household and extended family for anyone who is being overlooked, and reach out to them.
- Teach your children to show kindness to people outside your tribe, church or social class, and let them see you do it.

## **Questions for reflection**

1. Why do you think God placed the command to love your neighbour among commands about wages, markets and courts?
2. In the parable of the Good Samaritan, which character are you most like in your home right now?
3. Is there anyone in your family you are “hiding from”? What would it take to stop hiding?
4. How does knowing that God loves you make it easier to love others well?

## Point 3: Matthew 22:37-40 – The Two Pegs

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

3. Matthew 22:37-40 (MSG): Jesus said, “Love the Lord your God with all your passion and prayer and intelligence.” This is the most important, the first on any list. But there is a second to set alongside it: “Love others as well as you love yourself.” These two commands are pegs; everything in God’s Law and the Prophets hangs from them.

*Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets.*

**Matthew 22:37-40 (KJV)**

In the last days before His crucifixion, Jesus was being tested with hard questions in the temple. A lawyer among the Pharisees asked, “Master, which is the great commandment in the law?” (Matthew 22:36). Jesus answered by joining together the two passages we have just studied: Deuteronomy 6:5 and Leviticus 19:18. The leaflet has deliberately followed the same path. Point 1 gave the command to love God; point 2 gave the command to love neighbour; point 3 shows that Jesus Himself put them side by side as the summary of everything God requires.

### The picture of the pegs

The King James Version says that all the law and the prophets “hang” on these two commandments. The Message paraphrase quoted in the leaflet turns this into a picture: the two commands are pegs, and everything else hangs from them. Imagine the wooden pegs or hooks on a wall where a household hangs its clothes, bags and keys. If the pegs are strong and firmly fixed, everything stays in place. If the pegs are pulled out, everything falls to the floor in a heap. In the same way, all the other commands of Scripture – about honesty, purity, justice, worship, generosity and family life – find their meaning and strength in love for God and love for people. Take away love, and religion becomes a pile of rules on the floor.

This helps families understand why they obey God. Children are not only told “Do not lie” because it is a rule, but because lying damages love and trust. A husband is faithful to his wife not merely to avoid scandal, but because he loves God and loves her. When rules are hung on the pegs of love, they make sense and they last.

### Love fulfils the law

The apostle Paul makes the same point in his letter to the Romans, showing how the individual commandments are really love in action.

*Owe no man any thing, but to love one another: for he that loveth another hath fulfilled the law. For this, Thou shalt not commit adultery, Thou shalt not kill, Thou shalt not steal, Thou shalt not bear false witness, Thou shalt not covet; and if there be any other commandment, it is briefly comprehended in this saying, namely, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. Love worketh no ill to his neighbour: therefore love is the fulfilling of the law.*

**Romans 13:8-10 (KJV)**

Think of these commandments inside a home. Adultery betrays a spouse and wounds children. Killing includes the slow killing of a person's spirit through contempt, and Jesus Himself linked murder to anger and insult (Matthew 5:21-22). Stealing includes taking family money that was meant for school fees or feeding, or cheating a sibling out of an inheritance. False witness includes lying to your spouse about where you were or what you spent. Coveting includes the constant comparison with other families that breeds discontent. In each case, the person who truly loves will not do these things. Love does no harm to its neighbour, and so love keeps the law from the inside.

### **Why the order matters**

Jesus called love for God “the first and great commandment”. The second is “like unto it”, closely related and equally binding, but it comes second. When the first is missing, love for people easily becomes shallow or exhausted, depending entirely on our own goodness and collapsing when people disappoint us. The Bible says, “We love him, because he first loved us” (1 John 4:19). The love we receive from God is the fuel for the love we give. When the second is missing, love for God becomes empty religion: long prayers, loud worship and generous offerings in church, with pride, cruelty or dishonesty at home and at work. A healthy Christian family needs both pegs firmly fixed.

### **Heart, soul and mind**

The leaflet's paraphrase (see the box above) expresses this in modern words. Jesus' words in the King James Version – heart, soul and mind – cover the whole person. Loving God with your heart involves your affections and desires. Loving Him with your soul involves your inner life and devotion. Loving Him with your mind involves your thinking: studying His word, making careful decisions, doing your work with excellence and refusing to switch off your conscience in business or politics. Parents can help children love God with their minds by encouraging questions, reading the Bible with understanding and showing that faith and careful thought belong together.

### **Practical steps**

- As a family, list some of the rules in your home and talk about how each one protects love for God or love for one another.
- When correcting a child, explain not only what they did wrong but how it hurt love and trust.

- Check your week: have you given time to loving God (prayer, worship, Scripture) and to loving people (time, help, kindness)? Adjust whichever is weaker.
- Memorise Matthew 22:37-39 together and recite it at family devotion for a week.

### Questions for reflection

1. Which of the two “pegs” is weaker in your life at the moment, and how can you tell?
2. Choose one of the commandments in Romans 13:9. How is keeping it an act of love in your home?
3. What happens in a family when rules are enforced without love? What happens when love is talked about without any rules?
4. How can you love God with your mind in your work or studies this week?

**Pull out the pegs of love, and every other command falls to the floor.**

## Point 4: 1 Corinthians 13 and the Yellow Card – Putting Love into Practice

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

4. 1 Corinthians 13:4-8a. The yellow card in your hand. How to practicalize the law of LOVE.

*Charity suffereth long, and is kind; charity envieth not; charity vaunteth not itself, is not puffed up, Doth not behave itself unseemly, seeketh not her own, is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil; Rejoiceth not in iniquity, but rejoiceth in the truth; Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things. Charity never faileth.*

**1 Corinthians 13:4-8a (KJV)**

### Why the King James Version says “charity”

When the King James Version was published in 1611, the English word “charity” carried a richer meaning than it usually does today. It came from the Latin word for love and was used here to translate the Greek word agape, the self-giving love that seeks the good of another whatever the cost. Today “charity” often means giving money to the poor, but in this chapter it means love itself. Wherever you read “charity” in 1 Corinthians 13, read “love”. This is the same love with which God loved the world and gave His Son (John 3:16).

Just before this passage Paul says that tongues, prophecy, knowledge, mountain-moving faith and even giving away all his goods would profit nothing without love (1 Corinthians 13:1-3) – a sobering word for any church or family proud of its spiritual activity but careless about love.

## The yellow card in your hand

The leaflet speaks of “the yellow card in your hand”. The outline does not describe the card, but Practical Love Publications is known for giving out LoveCards, and the most likely meaning is that hearers were holding a yellow LoveCard listing the qualities of love, probably drawn from this very passage and related Scriptures. The point is that love is not a vague feeling that no one can measure. God has described it in clear, practical terms that you can hold in your hand, read in the morning and check yourself against at night. If you do not have a card, the passage itself is your card. Copy 1 Corinthians 13:4-8 onto a piece of paper and keep it in your Bible, your bag or on your wall.

The leaflet then says, “How to practicalize the law of LOVE.” “Practicalize” is not a standard English word, but its meaning is clear: to put something into daily practice. The law of love must move from the page to the kitchen and from the sermon to daily life.

## Love in the home, quality by quality

**Love suffers long and is kind.** To suffer long means to be patient with people over a long period, not only for a moment. A husband is patient when his wife is tired or unwell and the house is not as he would like. A wife is patient with a husband who is slow to change. Parents are patient with a child who learns slowly. Kindness is patience in action: not only holding back anger, but actively doing good, speaking gently and helping without being asked.

**Love envies not, vaunts not itself, is not puffed up.** Envy resents another person’s blessing. In a home it can show up as a husband who feels threatened when his wife earns more or is more respected, or siblings who cannot rejoice at each other’s success. To vaunt oneself is to boast; to be puffed up is to be inflated with pride. A proud parent cannot admit fault. A proud spouse keeps score of who contributes more. Love celebrates others and does not need to be the centre of attention.

**Love does not behave itself unseemly and seeks not her own.** Unseemly behaviour is rude, shameful or inappropriate conduct: insulting a spouse in front of the children, shouting at parents, mocking a child in public, or treating a house help without dignity. To seek not one’s own is to stop insisting on one’s own way, comfort and rights at the expense of others. A home where everyone demands their rights becomes a battlefield; a home where each seeks the good of others becomes a place of rest.

**Love is not easily provoked and thinks no evil.** Some homes live on edge because one person explodes at the smallest thing. Love has a long fuse. To think no evil means not keeping a record of wrongs and not assuming the worst about the other person’s motives. A wife who hears her husband is late does not immediately imagine unfaithfulness; a parent does not treat every mistake as rebellion. Love forgives and does not bring up old offences as weapons in new quarrels.

**Love rejoices not in iniquity but rejoices in the truth.** Love is never glad about wrongdoing, even when it benefits the family or hurts someone we dislike. It does not celebrate a dishonest deal, cover a child’s cheating, or enjoy gossip about a relative’s fall. It rejoices when truth is spoken and done. A

loving home is a truthful home, where family members can admit mistakes without fear of being destroyed.

**Love bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things. Love never fails.** To bear all things is to cover and protect, not to expose each other's weaknesses to outsiders. To believe all things is to be ready to trust and to give the benefit of the doubt, not to be foolish or blind to real danger. To hope all things is to refuse to give up on a prodigal child or a struggling marriage. To endure is to keep going through hard seasons. Love never fails: it outlasts gifts, knowledge and every earthly thing. Bearing all things never means that anyone must remain in a situation of violence or abuse; love can protect others and seek help while still hoping for change.

### Using the card as a mirror

A simple and humbling exercise is to read the passage aloud and put your own name in place of "charity": "Ngozi suffers long and is kind; Ngozi envies not ..." Very soon you will reach a line you cannot say honestly. That is the point. The card is a mirror that shows us how far we fall short, and it drives us to Christ, the only one who has loved perfectly. Then, by His Spirit, we begin to grow in each quality. Do not use the card to measure your spouse while excusing yourself. Use it first on your own heart.

### Practical steps

- Keep a copy of 1 Corinthians 13:4-8 – or your yellow LoveCard – where you will see it every day.
- Choose one quality of love each week and practise it deliberately with each member of your family.
- At the end of the day, read the list and ask God to show you where you failed and where you grew.
- When there is a quarrel at home, pause and ask together which quality of love is missing.
- Help children learn the qualities of love by praising them when they show patience, kindness or truthfulness.

### Questions for reflection

1. When you put your own name in place of "charity" in 1 Corinthians 13:4-7, at which line did you have to stop?
2. Which quality of love does your family most need at this time?
3. What does it mean for a husband, a wife, a child and a parent to "seek not her own" in practical terms?
4. How can the qualities of love move from the card into your daily conduct, so that they are not only words on paper?

**Love has a checklist, and God has put it in your hand.**

## Point 5: A Statement of Facts and the Crucial Question

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

#### 5. Statement of facts and the CRUCIAL QUESTION FOR ALL NIGERIANS.

Here the leaflet announces a statement of facts and a crucial question for all Nigerians, but it does not print either of them. The preacher presumably spoke them aloud. These notes do not claim to know his exact words. Instead, they draw the facts and the question from the points that follow in the leaflet itself (points 7, 8 and 9), and they say plainly that the wording below is the notes' own framing.

### The facts the outline points to

- Nigeria is a very religious country. Churches and mosques are full, prayer meetings run through the night, and the name of God is on vehicles, shops and lips everywhere.
- Nigeria is richly blessed with natural and human resources, including large oil and gas reserves, fertile land and a large young population.
- Yet Nigeria has often ranked poorly in Transparency International's Corruption Perceptions Index, and the nation is widely associated with corruption and dishonesty.
- Ordinary families feel the results: bribes demanded for services that should be free, fraud, and public money that does not reach the people it was meant to serve.

### The crucial question, as framed in these notes

**If Nigeria is so religious and so richly blessed, why is it known for wickedness and corruption – and what part does my family play?**

The question has two halves. The first half is easy to discuss. We can blame leaders, colonial history, the economy or people from other parts of the country. There is truth in many of these explanations, and these notes do not excuse wicked leadership. But the second half of the question is the one the leaflet presses hardest, as point 9 will show. A nation is made up of families. If corruption is found in the nation, it has been learned, excused or tolerated somewhere in its homes.

*Righteousness exalteth a nation: but sin is a reproach to any people.*

**Proverbs 14:34 (KJV)**

Proverbs does not say that religion exalts a nation, or resources, or population. It says righteousness does. In the Bible, righteousness means right standing with God showing itself in right dealings with people:

honest scales, fair judgement, faithful marriages, paid wages, truthful words. A nation where people pray much but deal falsely with one another is not yet exalted by righteousness. Sin, on the other hand, is a “reproach”, a public disgrace, to any people, whatever their size or wealth.

Notice too that the leaflet puts the question to all Nigerians – not only to politicians, the rich or one group of people. Every citizen, in every home, has a share in the answer. For Christians the question is sharper still. God spoke through Isaiah of a people who “draw near me with their mouth, and with their lips do honour me, but have removed their heart far from me” (Isaiah 29:13), and Jesus applied those words to the religious people of His own day (Matthew 15:7-9). It is possible to be busy with worship and still be far from God in the way we treat people.

## **Begin by examining yourself**

*Examine yourselves, whether ye be in the faith; prove your own selves. Know ye not your own selves, how that Jesus Christ is in you, except ye be reprobates?*

**2 Corinthians 13:5 (KJV)**

Paul wrote these words to the church in Corinth, a church that had many spiritual gifts (1 Corinthians 1:7) but also quarrels, pride and moral failures. Instead of looking only at the faults of others, he told them to examine themselves. Jesus taught the same when He said, “first cast out the beam out of thine own eye” (Matthew 7:5). The crucial question is not asked to make Nigerians hopeless. Every good doctor knows that treatment begins with an honest diagnosis. God asks hard questions because He intends to heal.

## **Practical steps**

- Before discussing what is wrong with Nigeria, spend time asking God to show you what is wrong in your own conduct.
- As a family, talk honestly about situations where you have been tempted to join in dishonest practices, and how you responded.
- Refuse to speak about the nation only with complaint; add prayer and a personal decision to do right.

## **Discuss together**

1. Why do you think a nation can be very religious and still be known for corruption?
2. How would you answer the crucial question for your own family?
3. What is the difference between religion and righteousness according to Proverbs 14:34?
4. Why is self-examination harder, but more useful, than blaming others?

## Point 6: 1 John 4:20-21 – The Commandment Is to Love

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

6. Number 43 on the yellow card: 1 John 4:20-21. The Commandment is to love.

The leaflet again refers to the yellow card, this time to “number 43”. This suggests that the card carries a numbered list of love Scriptures or statements, and that item 43 points to 1 John 4:20-21. If you have the card, find the number; if not, the verses themselves carry the message.

*If a man say, I love God, and hateth his brother, he is a liar: for he that loveth not his brother whom he hath seen, how can he love God whom he hath not seen? And this commandment have we from him, That he who loveth God love his brother also.*

**1 John 4:20-21 (KJV)**

The apostle John, traditionally recognised as the writer of this letter, is often called the apostle of love. He was writing to believers unsettled by people who claimed to know God but did not live by His commandments (1 John 2:4). John will not accept such a claim. “Beloved, let us love one another: for love is of God ... He that loveth not knoweth not God; for God is love” (1 John 4:7-8). Love is not an optional extra for especially gentle Christians. It is a commandment.

### The brother you see and the God you do not see

John’s reasoning is simple. Your brother is visible; you see him every day, with all his faults. God is invisible. If you cannot love the person in front of you, your claim to love the invisible God is empty. Apply this to the home. A man who prays loudly at every vigil but has not spoken kindly to his wife in weeks; a mother who serves faithfully in church while one of her children lives in fear of her; brothers who sit in the same congregation but have not settled their quarrel – John would say that their love for God is not what they think it is.

### Am I my brother’s keeper?

*And the LORD said unto Cain, Where is Abel thy brother? And he said, I know not: Am I my brother’s keeper?*

**Genesis 4:9 (KJV)**

The first murder in the Bible happened inside the first family, and it grew out of an act of worship. Cain and Abel both brought offerings to God; when God accepted Abel’s offering and not Cain’s, Cain became angry and killed his brother (Genesis 4:3-8). Worship and hatred stood side by side. When God asked where Abel was, Cain lied and denied any responsibility. God’s reply – “the voice of thy brother’s blood crieth unto me from the ground” (Genesis 4:10) – shows that He holds us responsible for how we

treat our brothers and sisters. Sibling rivalry, jealousy over a parent's favour, and quarrels over inheritance are not small matters to God.

## Love proved by action

*But whoso hath this world's good, and seeth his brother have need, and shutteth up his bowels of compassion from him, how dwelleth the love of God in him? My little children, let us not love in word, neither in tongue; but in deed and in truth.*

**1 John 3:17-18 (KJV)**

“Bowels of compassion” is the King James Version's way of describing deep, heartfelt pity. John says love must be seen in deed and in truth. In a family this might mean helping a sibling's child with school fees, visiting an ageing parent instead of only sending messages, giving your spouse real attention, or offering an apology without excuses. Because love is commanded, it is more than a feeling. You can choose to act in love even when feelings are cold, and God gives the power to do so.

Loving your brother does not mean supporting his wrongdoing, lending money you cannot afford to lose, or placing yourself in danger. Sometimes love says no, sets boundaries or involves others who can help. But it never stops caring, praying and seeking the other person's good.

## Practical steps

- Identify one family member you find hard to love and do one concrete act of kindness for them this week.
- If there is an unresolved quarrel among siblings or relatives, pray about it and take a first step towards reconciliation.
- Replace one promise of love in words with one act of love in deed.

## Questions for reflection

1. Why does John say that a person who hates his brother is a liar when he claims to love God?
2. In what ways do families today repeat Cain's question, “Am I my brother's keeper?”
3. What is one area where your love has been in word and tongue but not yet in deed and truth?
4. How can love set wise boundaries without becoming cold?

# Point 7: Vertical Worship and Horizontal Worship

## FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

7. Vertical worship. Horizontal worship.

I. Wole Soyinka

II. Tai Solarin

China, Japan, India: vertical worship nil.

JAPAN: paternity leave. By their fruits we shall know them, i.e. only human resources.

The leaflet uses two simple words, vertical and horizontal. A helpful way to picture them – and this picture is these notes’ own, not the leaflet’s – is the cross. It has an upright beam that points to heaven and a crossbeam that stretches out to either side. Vertical worship is our love, devotion and obedience towards God: prayer, praise, Scripture, faith. Horizontal worship is love, justice and service towards people: honesty, kindness, fairness, care for the weak. The two great commandments of point 3 are the two beams. A cross with only one beam is not a cross.

*He hath shewed thee, O man, what is good; and what doth the LORD require of thee, but to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God?*

**Micah 6:8 (KJV)**

The prophet Amos spoke to a nation that was very religious but deeply unjust. Its people kept feasts and offered sacrifices, yet they took bribes and turned aside the poor in the gate (Amos 5:12). God’s response was blunt: “Take thou away from me the noise of thy songs ... But let judgment run down as waters, and righteousness as a mighty stream” (Amos 5:23-24). Vertical worship without horizontal worship is noise in God’s ears. James says the same in the New Testament: “faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone” (James 2:17).

## By their fruits

*Ye shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of thistles? Even so every good tree bringeth forth good fruit; but a corrupt tree bringeth forth evil fruit.*

**Matthew 7:16-17 (KJV)**

Jesus first spoke these words as a test for false prophets: do not judge a preacher by his words or his title but by the fruit of his life. The principle applies widely. A tree is known by what it produces, not by its label. A family, a church or a nation that claims to love God should be recognisable by its fruit in the way it treats people.

## The outline’s examples

The leaflet names two well-known Nigerians and three Asian nations, but it does not explain them in detail. What follows is the notes' reading of the challenge the outline appears to make. Wole Soyinka won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1986, the first African to receive it. During the Nigerian Civil War he was detained for his stand for peace, and he has spoken critically of organised religion. Tai Solarin (1922–1994) was an educator and social critic who founded Mayflower School in Ikenne. He was openly a non-believer, yet he was widely admired for his discipline, simplicity of life and public integrity.

The challenge seems to be this: here are men who stood apart from, or openly questioned, organised religion, yet many Nigerians have admired qualities such as courage, discipline and public integrity in their lives. These notes make no judgement about their souls; that belongs to God alone. The point is aimed at believers. If such qualities can be admired in people who have questioned organised religion, what excuse does a praying, church-going family have for lying, cheating or cruelty? Paul observed something similar when he wrote that Gentiles without the law sometimes “do by nature the things contained in the law” (Romans 2:14). None of this means that good works save anyone. Salvation is by grace through faith (Ephesians 2:8-9). But true faith should produce more love, not less.

The leaflet then says of China, Japan and India, “vertical worship nil”. Christians are a small minority in all three nations, so this is best read as shorthand for very little Christian worship, not a claim that no one there prays.

The phrase “only human resources” fits Japan especially, a country widely noted for having limited natural resources and building its strength largely on the skills, discipline and labour of its people. The leaflet also mentions paternity leave. Japan's childcare leave law allows fathers as well as mothers to take extended leave, up to around a year. On paper this is one of the most generous entitlements for fathers in the world, though for many years relatively few fathers actually used it.

The lesson for us is twofold. A nation can show that it values families and people through its laws and priorities. And a good policy on paper is not enough; habits must change too. Churches and Christian employers can learn from this: preaching about family life means little if every evening and weekend keeps fathers and mothers away from home.

### **Not comparison, but conviction**

The purpose of these examples is not to praise other nations as better in God's sight, or to suggest that faith in Christ does not matter. Every nation has its own sins. The purpose is conviction: our vertical worship must bear horizontal fruit. Jesus said, “Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father which is in heaven” (Matthew 5:16).

### **Practical steps**

- Each week, pair one act of vertical worship with one act of horizontal worship – for example, after Sunday service, visit, call or help someone in need.

- Ask a trusted friend or colleague to tell you honestly whether your conduct at work matches the faith you profess, and what fruit they see in your family.
- Be willing to learn discipline, punctuality and integrity from anyone's good example, while holding firmly to your faith in Christ.
- Fathers: where your work allows, arrange your time so that you are present for family devotion, meals and important moments in your children's lives.
- Church leaders and workers: plan meetings so that parents are not kept away from their homes night after night.

### Questions for reflection

1. In your own life, which beam of the cross is stronger – the vertical or the horizontal?
2. Why do you think God called Israel's worship "noise" in Amos 5:23?
3. What fruit would a neighbour, colleague or house help see in your family?
4. What could your church do to show that it values fathers' presence and family time, not only in preaching but in practice?

**Worship that reaches up must also reach out.**

## Point 8: Nigeria – Richly Blessed, Yet Short of Love

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

8. NIGERIA: all natural resources – blessing. Nigeria known for wickedness and corruption – nil horizontal worship.

Point 5 set out the facts; point 8 gives the leaflet's own verdict on them. The land's natural resources are, in the leaflet's word, a blessing, and every such blessing comes from God. Yet the nation is widely known for wickedness and corruption. The leaflet's diagnosis is short: "nil horizontal worship". The problem is not a lack of resources or a lack of prayer. It is a lack of love expressed as honesty, justice and service.

*And thou say in thine heart, My power and the might of mine hand hath gotten me this wealth. But thou shalt remember the LORD thy God: for it is he that giveth thee power to get wealth, that he may establish his covenant which he sware unto thy fathers, as it is this day.*

**Deuteronomy 8:17-18 (KJV)**

Moses warned Israel that abundance could make them proud and forgetful. Wealth comes from God, and He gives it for a purpose: to establish His covenant, not to feed greed. Natural resources are a trust to be stewarded for the good of all. When they are treated as a prize to be grabbed, the blessing becomes a source of conflict, pollution, poverty and bitterness.

### **When blessing is not matched by love**

*When the righteous are in authority, the people rejoice: but when the wicked beareth rule, the people mourn.*

**Proverbs 29:2 (KJV)**

Leadership matters greatly, and Nigerians have every right to long for righteous leaders. But leaders do not appear from nowhere. They are raised in homes, taught in schools and formed in churches and mosques. And corruption is not only at the top. The small bribe at a checkpoint, the inflated receipt in an office, the name added to a payroll for someone who does no work and the large public contract that disappears all grow from the same root: loving self and money more than God and neighbour. A nation's leaders often reflect the values its people tolerate.

### **Stewardship is learned at home**

The way a nation handles its wealth is learned, on a small scale, in the way families handle what they are given. Jesus said, "He that is faithful in that which is least is faithful also in much: and he that is unjust in the least is unjust also in much" (Luke 16:10). A child who sees parents waste food, damage public property without concern, bypass the electricity meter or take more than their fair share of an inheritance learns that resources exist to be grabbed. A child who sees parents share fairly, look after what they have and return extra change learns stewardship. Tomorrow's ministers, governors and accountants are children in today's homes.

### **Not a hopeless nation**

*If my people, which are called by my name, shall humble themselves, and pray, and seek my face, and turn from their wicked ways; then will I hear from heaven, and will forgive their sin, and will heal their land.*

**2 Chronicles 7:14 (KJV)**

God spoke these words to Solomon about Israel, but the principle has encouraged believers in every land. Notice who God addresses: "my people". Healing begins not with the government but with those called by God's name humbling themselves, praying and turning from their own wicked ways. When the Jews were exiled in Babylon, God told them to "seek the peace of the city ... and pray unto the LORD for it: for in the peace thereof shall ye have peace" (Jeremiah 29:7). Christians in Nigeria are called to do the same: to pray for the nation and to work for its good.

Every honest civil servant, trader who uses a fair measure, teacher who refuses to sell marks, police officer who will not extort, and family that refuses shortcuts is a seed of a different Nigeria. The gap between worship and fruit can be closed, one home at a time.

## Practical steps

- Pray regularly as a family for Nigeria, naming leaders, your state and your community.
- Thank God together for specific blessings of the land, and discuss how to use your share of those blessings honestly.
- Decide as a family on one form of corruption you will not take part in, whatever it costs.

## Questions for reflection

1. Why can great natural wealth become a curse instead of a blessing when love is missing?
2. How are the values of leaders connected to the values tolerated in ordinary homes?
3. According to 2 Chronicles 7:14, what must God's people do before the land is healed?
4. What small act of honesty could your family practise that would be a seed of a better nation?

# Point 9: Everybody's Family Is Guilty

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

9. Everybody's family in Nigeria is guilty!! How? The characteristic of love in the family will reveal how you and your family are contributing to the wickedness in Nigeria. Pray to God to give you power to LOVE members of your family.

These are strong words, and they are meant to wake us up. It is easy to hear a message about national corruption and think of other people. The leaflet will not let any family off the hook, including the families of pastors and church workers. Yet the purpose is not condemnation. The Bible brings us to guilt so that it can bring us to grace.

*For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God;*

**Romans 3:23 (KJV)**

When Nehemiah heard of the ruin of Jerusalem, he did not blame others first. He prayed, "both I and my father's house have sinned" (Nehemiah 1:6). He included himself and his family in the confession. That is the attitude this point asks of us.

## How the home feeds the nation

The leaflet says the “characteristic of love in the family” reveals how a family contributes to wickedness in the nation. Children learn far more from what they see than from what they are told. Consider some of the ways homes quietly train the next generation for corruption.

- **Lying.** A parent tells a child, “If he calls, tell him I am not in.” The child learns that lying is acceptable when it is convenient.
- **Bribery.** Parents pay for “help” in examinations or for a certificate their child has not earned. The child learns that results can be bought.
- **Favouritism.** One child is praised and another constantly compared unfavourably; sons are valued above daughters; one set of relatives is always preferred. Children learn that fairness depends on connections.
- **Violence.** Quarrels are settled by shouting, insults or blows. Children learn that power belongs to whoever is strongest or loudest.
- **Greed.** People are measured by their cars, houses and money, and the first question about a job is “How much?” rather than “Is it honest?” Children learn to worship wealth.
- **Contempt for others.** Jokes and remarks belittle other tribes, religions or poorer people. Children learn to despise their neighbours.

Every corrupt official, fraudster and violent person was once a child in someone’s home. This does not remove personal responsibility. “The son shall not bear the iniquity of the father, neither shall the father bear the iniquity of the son” (Ezekiel 18:20). Each person answers to God. But homes shape consciences, and a home without love and truth makes wrongdoing much easier.

## Grace for guilty families

*If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.*

**1 John 1:9 (KJV)**

The right response to guilt is not despair or self-defence but confession. “He that covereth his sins shall not prosper: but whoso confesseth and forsaketh them shall have mercy” (Proverbs 28:13). Confession includes forsaking – turning away from the practice. A family can come before God together, admit how it has fallen short and receive fresh mercy. For those in Christ there is “no condemnation” (Romans 8:1), which means conviction is an invitation to change, not a sentence of shame.

## Power to love

This part of the leaflet closes with a prayer request: ask God for power to love the members of your family. That is a humble admission that we cannot do this in our own strength. Some family members are very hard to love. Old wounds, disappointments and personality clashes run deep. But God does not

command love without also supplying it.

*And hope maketh not ashamed; because the love of God is shed abroad in our hearts by the Holy Ghost which is given unto us.*

**Romans 5:5 (KJV)**

The Holy Spirit pours God's own love into the believer's heart, and love is the first fruit of the Spirit listed in Galatians 5:22. Pray specifically: "Lord, give me patience with my husband," "Give me kindness towards my mother-in-law," "Help me to stop favouring one child." God answers such prayers, often by showing us one small loving action to take next.

### **Practical steps**

- Hold a calm family meeting and name, without blaming any one person, one of the six patterns above that has been present in your home.
- Confess it together in prayer, and agree on one concrete change – for example, no one will ever again be asked to say "I am not in" when you are.
- Where your example has taught your children something wrong, tell them so plainly and apologise.
- Pray every day this week for power to love one named family member, and write down one loving action God shows you to take.

### **Questions for reflection**

1. Which of the six patterns listed above has been present in your home, even in a small way?
2. Why is it important that confession includes forsaking the sin, not only admitting it?
3. Which family member do you most need God's power to love, and what will you ask Him for?
4. What would change in Nigeria if families began to take this point seriously?

## **Point 9 Continued: Humble Parents and the Pastor of the Home**

### **FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET**

- Daddy and mummy, be humble; allow family members to assess you.
- Father, be a role model – the pastor of the church in your home.

CHARITY BEGINS AT HOME.

### **Daddy and mummy, be humble**

Respect for parents and elders is a precious part of Nigerian culture and it agrees with Scripture. But respect can harden into a wall, where parents can never be questioned and children, or even a spouse, dare not say when they are hurt. The leaflet asks parents to do something many find difficult: to be humble enough to let family members assess them. “God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble” (James 4:6). When the prophet Nathan confronted King David over his sin, David did not punish the messenger; he said, “I have sinned against the LORD” (2 Samuel 12:13). A parent who can receive correction teaches children to do the same.

## **A simple family assessment**

Choose a calm time, not in the middle of a quarrel. Parents should be the first to invite assessment, and should promise that no one will be punished or mocked for an honest answer. Children should be taught to speak respectfully. Younger children can answer simply; older children and a spouse can answer more fully, perhaps in writing. Use questions like these, based on 1 Corinthians 13.

1. When do you feel most loved in this family?
2. Is there anything I do that makes you afraid, ashamed or discouraged?
3. Do I listen to you before I get angry?
4. Do I keep my promises?
5. Do you feel I treat anyone in this home better or worse than others?
6. What is one thing you would like me to change this month?

When you hear the answers, thank each person, do not argue or defend yourself, apologise where needed and pray together. Then return to the same questions after a month to see what has changed. If anyone is too afraid to answer honestly, or if the answers reveal violence or abuse, do not try to handle it within the family alone; seek help from a trusted church leader and, where needed, the proper authorities.

## **Father, the pastor of the church in your home**

*Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it;*

**Ephesians 5:25 (KJV)**

The Bible gives husbands and fathers a special responsibility to lead, but the model for that leadership is Christ, who gave Himself for the church. Headship is not dictatorship; it is sacrificial service. Paul says a church leader must be one who rules his own house well, “For if a man know not how to rule his own house, how shall he take care of the church of God?” (1 Timothy 3:5). Every father is in a sense the pastor of the small church that is his home. Job rose early to offer sacrifices for each of his children (Job 1:5). Joshua declared before the whole nation, “as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD” (Joshua 24:15). A father leads by example: praying with his family, being faithful to his wife, working honestly, admitting his mistakes, and being present rather than always away.

## Honouring the role of mothers

The leaflet speaks especially to fathers, but it begins by addressing “daddy and mummy” together. Paul remembered that Timothy’s faith “dwelt first in thy grandmother Lois, and thy mother Eunice” (2 Timothy 1:5). Older women are to teach younger women “to love their husbands, to love their children” (Titus 2:4). In many Nigerian homes it is the mother who first teaches children to pray. Where a father is absent, has died or does not believe, a mother can still make her home a church, and God promises to be “a father of the fatherless, and a judge of the widows” (Psalm 68:5).

## Children and parents

*Children, obey your parents in the Lord: for this is right. Honour thy father and mother; (which is the first commandment with promise;) That it may be well with thee, and thou mayest live long on the earth. And, ye fathers, provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord.*

**Ephesians 6:1-4 (KJV)**

Children are called to obey and honour their parents. Parents are called not to provoke their children to wrath. “Fathers, provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged” (Colossians 3:21). Loving correction is part of good parenting, but the Bible never approves of harshness or abuse: humiliating children, cursing them, wounding them, starving them as punishment, or treating relatives’ children and house helps worse than one’s own. Discipline should be calm, fair, explained and aimed at training, not at releasing a parent’s anger.

If there is violence in a home – against a wife, a husband, a child or a house help – safety must come first. Seek help from trusted church leaders and from the proper authorities. Scripture never requires anyone to remain in danger in order to prove their love or their faith.

## Charity begins at home

*But if any provide not for his own, and specially for those of his own house, he hath denied the faith, and is worse than an infidel.*

**1 Timothy 5:8 (KJV)**

Paul also said children should “learn first to shew piety at home, and to requite their parents” (1 Timothy 5:4). Providing for your own includes food, shelter and school fees, but also time, attention, protection and care for ageing parents. “Charity begins at home” does not mean love should stop at home. Paul said, “let us do good unto all men, especially unto them who are of the household of faith” (Galatians 6:10). Home is where love starts and is trained, so that it can go out to everyone.

## Questions for reflection

1. Parents: how do you usually react when a child or spouse points out a fault? What does that teach them?
2. Fathers: in what ways are you leading your home as a pastor who serves, and where have you been absent?
3. How can your family keep loving discipline while removing anything harsh or humiliating?
4. What does “charity begins at home” require of you this week?

**Love learned at the family table is love that can serve the nation.**

## Point 10: Home and Church Together

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

#### 10. HOME + CHURCH:

I. John Mark’s mother’s home

II. Paul and Silas

III. Peter + love from John Mark’s mother’s home

For its first generations the church generally had no special buildings of the kind we know today. Believers met in the temple courts and “from house to house” (Acts 2:46). Homes were where they prayed, ate together, taught new believers and sheltered travelling ministers. The leaflet points to examples from the book of Acts to show how closely home and church worked together.

### I and III. Peter and the house of Mary, John Mark’s mother

*Peter therefore was kept in prison: but prayer was made without ceasing of the church unto God for him.*

**Acts 12:5 (KJV)**

King Herod had killed the apostle James and arrested Peter, planning to bring him out to the people after the feast (Acts 12:1-4). The night before, an angel woke Peter, his chains fell off, and he walked out through the prison gates. When he realised what had happened, he knew exactly where to go.

*And when he had considered the thing, he came to the house of Mary the mother of John, whose surname was Mark; where many were gathered together praying.*

**Acts 12:12 (KJV)**

In a time of persecution, Mary opened her home as a place of prayer for the church, at real risk to herself. Even the servant girl, Rhoda, knew Peter’s voice at the gate and ran in with joy (Acts 12:13-14). Peter found love, welcome and prayer in that house. Later he called Mark “my son” (1 Peter 5:13), showing a

close spiritual bond, and early Christian tradition connects Mark's Gospel with Peter's preaching. Mark himself once turned back from a missionary journey (Acts 13:13), causing a sharp disagreement between Paul and Barnabas (Acts 15:37-39), yet years later Paul wrote, "Take Mark, and bring him with thee: for he is profitable to me for the ministry" (2 Timothy 4:11). Mark came from a home where the church gathered to pray. After his failure Barnabas took Mark with him (Acts 15:39), and in time Paul could call him profitable for the ministry. Failure need not be final for a young person whom God is shaping, especially when praying homes and patient Christian leaders refuse to give up on him.

## II. Paul and Silas and the homes of Philippi

In Philippi, a businesswoman named Lydia believed the gospel, was baptised with her household, and insisted that Paul and his companions stay in her home (Acts 16:14-15). Later Paul and Silas were beaten and thrown into prison. At midnight they prayed and sang praises, an earthquake shook the prison, and the frightened jailer asked what he must do to be saved.

*And they said, Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved, and thy house. And they spake unto him the word of the Lord, and to all that were in his house. And he took them the same hour of the night, and washed their stripes; and was baptized, he and all his, straightway. And when he had brought them into his house, he set meat before them, and rejoiced, believing in God with all his house.*

**Acts 16:31-34 (KJV)**

Two households were transformed in one chapter. The jailer's home, which only hours earlier had no knowledge of Christ, became a place where wounds were washed, food was shared and God was worshipped. When Paul and Silas were released, they "entered into the house of Lydia" and comforted the believers there (Acts 16:40). The church in Philippi seems to have begun around these homes.

### The church in the house

Paul sent greetings to Priscilla and Aquila and "the church that is in their house" (Romans 16:5), and to Nymphas "and the church which is in his house" (Colossians 4:15). A Christian home can be a small church: a place of worship, God's word, prayer, fellowship, hospitality, correction and outreach. This does not replace the local congregation, where believers are not to forsake "the assembling of ourselves together" (Hebrews 10:25). Rather, healthy house churches feed the wider church, and the wider church strengthens the homes.

### Practical steps

- Make your home a regular place of prayer for your church, your pastor and believers in difficulty.
- Show hospitality: invite a church member, a new believer or a lonely person to share a meal.
- Support your house fellowship or cell group, or offer your home to host one if you are able.

- Pray for the salvation of every member of your household by name.

### Questions for reflection

1. If someone in trouble needed a place of prayer and love tonight, would they think of your home?
2. What can John Mark's story teach parents and churches about young people who fail?
3. How did the jailer show the change in his home immediately?
4. In what ways does your home strengthen your church, and your church strengthen your home?

## Point 10 Continued: The Rewards of Home and Church Operating in Love

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

#### REWARDS OF CHURCH AND HOME OPERATING IN LOVE:

- I. Those who honour, I will honour them.
- II. Jesus: I will build my church and the gates of hell will not prevail.
- III. The power of prayer from your family level, e.g. MOSES, DANIEL, ELIJAH, PAUL: Ananias and Sapphira.
- IV. New Covenant Baptist Church.
- V. The anointing from family churches increases the anointing of the church at large.
- VI. Psalm 105:15 – you become untouchable.

The leaflet lists six rewards. They are not wages we earn but fruits of God's faithfulness when homes and churches walk in love.

### I. God honours those who honour Him

The words "them that honour me I will honour, and they that despise me shall be lightly esteemed" (1 Samuel 2:30) were spoken to Eli the priest. His sons abused their priestly office, and God rebuked Eli for honouring his sons above Him (1 Samuel 2:29). The promise is set in a family failure: a leader who served at God's altar but would not correct his own household. God said He would judge Eli's house "because his sons made themselves vile, and he restrained them not" (1 Samuel 3:13). Eli spoke to his sons about their sin (1 Samuel 2:23-25), but he did not act to stop them. Parents who defend a child caught stealing, excuse a son who mistreats young women, or cover a daughter's lies to protect the family name are repeating Eli's mistake. Honouring God may mean loving, firm correction that costs the family some pride. Honouring God begins at home.

### II. A church hell cannot overcome

*And I say also unto thee, That thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church; and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it.*

**Matthew 16:18 (KJV)**

Jesus spoke these words after Peter confessed, “Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God” (Matthew 16:16). The church is built by Christ, on Christ and on that confession of who He is. In Bible times a city’s gates were its place of strength and of council, where the elders sat (see Ruth 4:1-2), so “the gates of hell” pictures all the power of death and evil gathered against God’s people. That power will not win. Believers are “lively stones” in Christ’s building (1 Peter 2:5), and homes of love are strong stones. Marriages will face pressure, children will face temptation and churches will face opposition, but none of these has the last word where Christ is building. A congregation made of praying, faithful families stands firm when trouble comes.

### **III. The power of prayer from the family level**

The leaflet names men of prayer. Moses interceded for Israel after the golden calf, and God turned from the judgement He had threatened (Exodus 32:11-14). Daniel prayed in his own house, windows open towards Jerusalem, three times a day, even when it was forbidden (Daniel 6:10). Elijah “was a man subject to like passions as we are”, yet his prayers shut and opened the heavens (James 5:17-18). Paul and Silas, as we saw in the previous section, prayed and sang praises at midnight, and a great earthquake opened the prison doors (Acts 16:25-26). Notice where Daniel prayed: “he went into his house” (Daniel 6:10). The leaflet’s phrase “from your family level” reminds us that answers affecting a whole nation often begin in private places of prayer. A husband and wife who pray together, and parents who pray over their children by name, are doing the same kind of work as these men of God, on a smaller stage.

The leaflet then names Ananias and Sapphira without explanation. These notes read them as a warning. In Acts 5 this husband and wife sold land, kept back part of the money, and pretended to give it all. The apostle Peter confronted Ananias first (Acts 5:3), and about three hours later asked Sapphira, “How is it that ye have agreed together to tempt the Spirit of the Lord?” (Acts 5:9). Agreement in a home is powerful in both directions. Jesus promised that when two agree in prayer it shall be done (Matthew 18:19); Ananias and Sapphira show that a couple can also agree in deceit, with terrible results.

### **IV. New Covenant Baptist Church**

The outline names New Covenant Baptist Church but gives no details. The preacher would presumably have explained why he mentioned it, and these notes do not attempt to supply that account. As you study, think of a congregation you know where strong, loving homes have made the church strong, and ask what your own church could learn.

### **V. Anointing that flows from family churches**

*Behold, how good and how pleasant it is for brethren to dwell together in unity! It is like the precious ointment upon the head, that ran down upon the beard, even Aaron's beard: that went down to the skirts of his garments; As the dew of Hermon, and as the dew that descended upon the mountains of Zion: for there the LORD commanded the blessing, even life for evermore.*

**Psalm 133:1-3 (KJV)**

The anointing oil flowed from Aaron's head down to his garments; the blessing moves outward from a place of unity. Jesus promised His presence where "two or three are gathered together in my name" (Matthew 18:20) – a husband and wife, a parent and child. A church's spiritual life is not only what happens on Sunday; it is the combined prayer and love of its homes. Where homes are united, the whole church is strengthened.

## **VI. "Touch not mine anointed"**

*When they were but a few men in number; yea, very few, and strangers in it. When they went from one nation to another, from one kingdom to another people; He suffered no man to do them wrong: yea, he reproved kings for their sakes; Saying, Touch not mine anointed, and do my prophets no harm.*

**Psalm 105:12-15 (KJV)**

In context, this psalm recalls how God protected Abraham, Isaac and Jacob and their small households as they wandered among other nations, even warning kings on their behalf (see Genesis 12:17 and 20:3). The comfort for a family walking in love is that God watches over His covenant people. It does not promise that no trouble will ever come – faithful believers still suffer, as the notes on point 12 explain – but it assures us that nothing can touch God's people outside His care.

"Untouchable" must be understood carefully. The verse is not a licence for pride, and it does not place any pastor, parent or believer above correction or the law. God sent Nathan to rebuke King David (2 Samuel 12:7), and Paul openly corrected Peter "because he was to be blamed" (Galatians 2:11). Christians are to be subject to the governing authorities (Romans 13:1). This verse must never be used to silence honest questions or to hide wrongdoing. Being kept by God and being accountable to others belong together.

## **Practical steps**

- Set one regular time each week when the whole family prays together for your church, your pastor and believers in difficulty.
- Parents: if a child's wrongdoing has been excused in your home, deal with it gently and honestly, remembering Eli.
- Husband and wife: agree together that you will never join in deceit, whether about money, church giving or anything else.

- Receive correction from church leaders humbly, and give honest, respectful feedback to leaders when it is needed.

### Questions for reflection

1. What does Eli's story teach about honouring God in the way we lead our homes?
2. Is your home's agreement being used for prayer and good, or has it ever been used to cover wrongdoing?
3. How could praying families increase the spiritual strength of your church?
4. Why is it dangerous to use Psalm 105:15 to avoid correction?

**A home that agrees in love and prayer strengthens the whole church.**

## Point 11: My Family and Personal Testimony

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

### 11. MY FAMILY AND PERSONAL TESTIMONY.

At this point the outline leaves space for the preacher to share his own family and personal testimony. The testimony itself is not recorded in the leaflet, and these notes do not attempt to reconstruct it. Instead, this section explains why testimony matters and helps you prepare your own.

*And they overcame him by the blood of the Lamb, and by the word of their testimony; and they loved not their lives unto the death.*

**Revelation 12:11 (KJV)**

*Come and hear, all ye that fear God, and I will declare what he hath done for my soul.*

**Psalm 66:16 (KJV)**

A testimony is an honest account of what God has done. It is not boasting about ourselves, and it includes our failures as well as God's mercy. When Jesus delivered the man in the country of the Gadarenes, He told him, "Go home to thy friends, and tell them how great things the Lord hath done for thee" (Mark 5:19). Testimony begins at home. God told Israel to set up memorial stones so that when children asked, "What mean ye by these stones?" parents could tell them of God's acts (Joshua 4:6-7). Families need their own "stones": remembered stories of God's faithfulness that children can hold on to.

Testimonies must be true. Exaggerated or invented stories dishonour God, however inspiring they sound. And family testimonies should be shared with care: do not expose a spouse's or child's private struggles in public without their consent, and never use a testimony to shame a family member.

## Why testimony belongs in a message on the family

It is fitting that an outline about raising loving families gives space to the preacher's own family. Teaching about the home carries weight when hearers can see that the teacher has tried to live it. Paul could say, "Be ye followers of me, even as I also am of Christ" (1 Corinthians 11:1) – not because he was perfect, but because his life pointed beyond himself to Christ. The psalmist resolved, "We will not hide them from their children, shewing to the generation to come the praises of the LORD" (Psalm 78:4). Every Christian family is called to do the same.

## Prompts for writing your family testimony

1. Where was your family spiritually when you first began to take God's command to love seriously?
2. Describe a time when love in your home was tested. What happened?
3. Describe a time you failed to love a family member, and how God and others helped restore the relationship.
4. What prayer has God answered for your family?
5. What change have you seen since practising one of the qualities of love in 1 Corinthians 13?
6. What would you like your children and grandchildren to remember about God's faithfulness to your family?

## Practical steps

- Keep a family notebook of answered prayers, with dates, and read from it at family devotion.
- Once a month, hold a short testimony time where each person shares one thing God has done.
- Ask grandparents or older relatives to tell how God helped them, and write their stories down.
- Before sharing a family testimony in public, ask the family members involved for their permission.

## Questions for reflection

1. Why do you think testimony is so powerful in overcoming the enemy?
2. What "memorial stones" of God's faithfulness does your family already have?
3. How can you share testimony in a way that honours every member of your family?

## Point 12: Blessing That Overflows

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

12. IT IS MANDATORY OR COMPULSORY FOR GOD TO BLESS YOU AND YOUR FAMILY MEMBERS, BLESSINGS FLOWING OVER TO YOUR CHURCH, ENVIRONMENT, PLACE OF WORK, THE NATION, ETC. YOU WILL DECREE A THING AND IT WILL BE ESTABLISHED. JOB 22:28-30.

Having called every family to repentance, love and prayer, the leaflet now speaks of hope. Its claim is bold: when a family walks in love, God's blessing on that family does not stay inside the house. It overflows to the church, the surroundings, the workplace and the nation.

*Thou shalt also decree a thing, and it shall be established unto thee: and the light shall shine upon thy ways. When men are cast down, then thou shalt say, There is lifting up; and he shall save the humble person. He shall deliver the island of the innocent: and it is delivered by the pureness of thine hands.*

**Job 22:28-30 (KJV)**

### Who spoke these words?

An honest study must note that these verses were spoken by Eliphaz the Temanite, one of Job's friends. In the same speech he wrongly accused Job of great wickedness (Job 22:5), and at the end of the book God said that the friends had not spoken of Him what was right (Job 42:7). So we should not build a doctrine on these words alone. Yet the principle in these verses – that God blesses the upright and that a person with clean hands becomes a channel of deliverance for others – is confirmed elsewhere in Scripture. The phrase “the island of the innocent” is hard to follow in the King James Version. Many Bible scholars understand the Hebrew here to mean that God will deliver even a person who is not innocent, through the clean hands of a righteous person who prays for him. Strikingly, the book ends with God sending Eliphaz and his friends to Job, and Job praying for them so that they were spared (Job 42:8-10). The innocent man's pure hands delivered the very people who had doubted him.

*The curse of the LORD is in the house of the wicked: but he blesseth the habitation of the just.*

**Proverbs 3:33 (KJV)**

God told Abraham, “I will bless thee ... and thou shalt be a blessing ... and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed” (Genesis 12:2-3). Blessing is meant to overflow. When Joseph served faithfully in Egypt, “the LORD blessed the Egyptian's house for Joseph's sake” (Genesis 39:5). God promised Israel that if they obeyed Him, blessings would “come on thee, and overtake thee” (Deuteronomy 28:1-2). A family that walks in love can bring blessing to its church, its street, its workplace and its nation.

### How blessing flows outward

Scripture says, “By the blessing of the upright the city is exalted: but it is overthrown by the mouth of the wicked” (Proverbs 11:11). In the church, a loving family gives faithfully, serves willingly and settles quarrels quickly. In the environment, it keeps its compound clean, helps neighbours in need and does not dump refuse where others must live with it. In the workplace, it works “heartily, as to the Lord, and not unto men” (Colossians 3:23), so colleagues see honesty and diligence. In the nation, it prays “for kings, and for all that are in authority” (1 Timothy 2:1-2), respects the law and serves honestly when given public responsibility.

### **What “mandatory” means – and does not mean**

No one can force God to do anything. He is sovereign. The leaflet’s strong word “mandatory” is best understood as confidence in God’s faithfulness to His own promises. “God is not a man, that he should lie ... hath he said, and shall he not do it?” (Numbers 23:19). God has bound Himself by His word, and “all the promises of God in him are yea, and in him Amen” (2 Corinthians 1:20). Our obedience does not purchase blessing; it places us where God has promised to bless.

Likewise, decreeing a thing is not a magic formula for commanding God. It is speaking and praying in line with His will, for “if we ask any thing according to his will, he heareth us” (1 John 5:14). Notice the condition in Job 22:30: deliverance comes “by the pureness of thine hands”. Bold declarations must come from honest lives.

### **When faithful people suffer**

God’s blessing is not always money or ease. It includes peace, a good name, children who walk in truth and His presence in trouble. Hebrews 11 lists heroes of faith who escaped the sword, and others, just as faithful, who were mocked, imprisoned and killed, and says “these all, having obtained a good report through faith, received not the promise” in their lifetime (Hebrews 11:39). Job himself suffered greatly while being righteous. So never assume that a struggling family is cursed, and never promise that faith guarantees wealth. God’s blessing is certain, but its form and timing belong to Him.

*And let us not be weary in well doing: for in due season we shall reap, if we faint not.*

**Galatians 6:9 (KJV)**

Keep sowing love and honesty even when the harvest seems slow. God has not forgotten.

### **Practical steps**

- Pray God’s promises over your family in line with His will, but check first that your hands are clean in the matter you are praying about.
- Choose one way this month for your family’s blessing to reach beyond your home: your street, your church or a colleague in need.
- When a faithful family you know is suffering, visit, pray and help rather than suspecting them.

## Questions for reflection

1. Why is it important to know who spoke Job 22:28-30, and how does the rest of Scripture support its principle?
2. How has God's blessing on one faithful person overflowed to others in your experience?
3. What is the difference between trusting God's promises and trying to force God?
4. How would you encourage a faithful family that is going through hardship?

## Point 13: The Thin Line Between Love of Money and Love of God

### FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

13. FINALLY: There is a thin line between LOVE OF MONEY AND LOVE OF GOD.

1. Love of money is the root of all evil and those who love it will perish. Proverbs 11:28.
2. Love of God is the root of all blessings.

The leaflet closes with the word “Finally”, and its last warning is about money. This is no change of subject. Points 5 to 9 asked why a praying, richly blessed nation is known for corruption. Much of the answer lies here: when money is loved more than God, love for neighbour gives way to bribes, fraud and neglect of the family. The leaflet sets two roots side by side and asks every home which one it is growing from.

*For the love of money is the root of all evil: which while some coveted after, they have erred from the faith, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows.*

**1 Timothy 6:10 (KJV)**

Money itself is not evil; it is the love of money that Paul condemns. Many readers understand this verse to mean that the love of money is a root from which every kind of evil can grow. Paul wrote it while warning against people who supposed “that gain is godliness” (1 Timothy 6:5) and reminding Timothy that “godliness with contentment is great gain” (1 Timothy 6:6).

*He that trusteth in his riches shall fall: but the righteous shall flourish as a branch.*

**Proverbs 11:28 (KJV)**

The leaflet cites this proverb to support its warning that those who love money will perish. Love of money shows itself as trust in riches – treating money as security, protection and saviour. Such a person “shall fall”, whether suddenly or slowly. The righteous, by contrast, “flourish as a branch”, drawing life from a root they did not create. That is the leaflet's second statement in picture form: the love of God is the root from which true blessing grows.

## Why the line is thin

*No man can serve two masters: for either he will hate the one, and love the other; or else he will hold to the one, and despise the other. Ye cannot serve God and mammon.*

**Matthew 6:24 (KJV)**

From the outside, a person who loves God and a person who loves money can look alike. Both work hard, pray for provision and give in church. The difference is in the heart: which one is master? “Mammon” means wealth treated as a lord. You may have crossed the line when you are willing to lie or compromise for money, when family time is always sacrificed for income, when you measure people by what they have, when you give in order to be seen or to “buy” a blessing, or when anxiety about money rules your home.

## Where the line is crossed in homes

**Marriage.** Bride price and wedding customs can honour families and bring them together. But when negotiations become a sale, when a daughter is valued by what she will bring, or when a couple begins marriage buried in debt for the sake of display, love of money has entered the home before the marriage has begun.

**Children’s education.** Every parent wants the best for their children. The line is crossed when parents borrow beyond their means to impress other parents with a school’s name, push a child into a course only for the money it may bring, or are so busy earning school fees that no one is raising the child.

**The “Nigerian factor”.** Paying to jump a queue, inflating a receipt, “settling” an official, or using church connections to win contracts are often excused with the words “that is how things work here”. Scripture warns, “the gift blindeth the wise” (Exodus 23:8), and “He that is greedy of gain troubleth his own house; but he that hateth gifts shall live” (Proverbs 15:27). Many families face real economic pressure, and choosing honesty can be costly. God sees that cost.

## The root of all blessings

*But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.*

**Matthew 6:33 (KJV)**

*Let your conversation be without covetousness; and be content with such things as ye have: for he hath said, I will never leave thee, nor forsake thee.*

**Hebrews 13:5 (KJV)**

In the King James Version, “conversation” means your whole way of life. Contentment is not laziness; it is freedom from the fear that God will not provide. Paul told the rich to “do good, that they be rich in good works, ready to distribute” (1 Timothy 6:18), and told former thieves to work so that they “may

have to give to him that needeth” (Ephesians 4:28). When God is loved first, money becomes a servant of love.

### **Practical steps**

- Husband and wife: be open with each other about income, spending and debts.
- Agree on family money rules: no dishonest income, no bribes, and regular giving to God and to people in need.
- Teach children to earn, save and give, and explain why you refuse shortcuts.
- Keep family time protected, even in busy seasons of work.

### **Questions for reflection**

1. What signs might show that money has become a master in your home?
2. How does Proverbs 11:28 help explain the difference between love of money and love of God?
3. Which of the areas above – marriage, education, or the “Nigerian factor” – is the greatest temptation for your family?
4. What would seeking first the kingdom of God look like in your family’s finances this month?

**When God is loved first, money becomes a servant of love.**

## **A Family Prayer and Commitment**

The teaching of this leaflet is meant to be lived, not only studied. Gather your household, read the prayer together, and talk through the commitments. Parents may wish to write the list in a notebook and let each family member sign it, then review it together once a month. Adapt the words to fit your household – for example, where a parent is raising children alone, or where grandparents or other relatives share your home.

### **A family prayer**

Heavenly Father, we thank You that You first loved us and gave Your Son for us. We confess that our family has not always loved You with all our heart, nor loved one another as we should. Forgive us for harsh words, grudges, lies, favouritism and the love of money. Pour Your love into our hearts by the Holy Spirit.

Teach the husband in this home to love his wife as Christ loved the church, and the wife to love her husband. Help us as parents to love our children with patience and wise correction, and help our children to honour and love their parents. Make us humble enough to hear one another, and make our home a

church where Your word is spoken, prayer is made and strangers are welcomed.

Let Your blessing on our home overflow to our church, our neighbours, our places of work and our nation. Heal Nigeria, Lord, and let righteousness begin with us. Keep us from loving money more than You. We ask this in the name of Jesus Christ our Lord. Amen.

### **Our family commitment**

1. We will love God first, and keep a regular time of family devotion.
2. We will practise one quality of love from 1 Corinthians 13 each week.
3. We will not keep grudges, but will seek to forgive and be reconciled quickly.
4. We will speak the truth at home and outside, and refuse bribes and dishonest shortcuts.
5. As parents, we will listen when our family members assess us, and we will correct our children without harshness or abuse.
6. We will treat every person in our home, including relatives and house helps, with dignity and fairness.
7. We will open our home for prayer and hospitality, and support our local church.
8. We will record and share God's faithfulness to our family truthfully.
9. We will seek first the kingdom of God and use our money to serve love.

**Charity begins at home – and from home it reaches the nation.**